

Public Panning Areas by State

Officially open places to pan for gold in 28 states, the rules for each one, and the official page to check before you load the truck.

"The best creek is the one you're allowed to stand in." — Grandpa Ezra

READ THIS FIRST

How to use this guide

1. **Find your state.** States are in alphabetical order. Each one lists named spots, the managing agency, what tools are allowed, and a source link.
2. **Read the rules paragraph.** It tells you whether a permit is needed and what's off limits, such as dredges, state parks, or fish spawning seasons.
3. **Call or check the official link before you go.** Rules, fees and seasons change every year. A two-minute call to the ranger district is the professional move.
4. **Check for claims.** Outside the specially set-aside areas, use Bonus 2 to make sure nobody holds a claim where you plan to dig.

Words you'll see

- **Casual use:** panning and hand tools that barely disturb the ground. Usually no permit needed on open BLM and Forest Service land.
- **Withdrawn area:** land closed to new mining claims, often set aside for the public to pan. These are the safest spots for beginners.
- **Pans only / hands and pans:** a gold pan and your hands. No shovels, sluices or detectors.
- **Pay-to-pan:** a private business that sells buckets of gravel or access to a creek. Great for families and for guaranteed color.

Honest note: This list was compiled in October 2026 from agency websites (BLM, U.S. Forest Service, state natural resource and geological agencies, state parks), with a few well-known secondary sources where the agency page wasn't available. It is not legal advice and not every open creek is listed. Fees and seasons marked "confirm" are the ones most likely to change.

States in this guide

- Alabama
- Alaska
- Arizona
- California
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- Georgia
- Idaho
- Indiana
- Maine
- Maryland
- Michigan
- Minnesota
- Montana
- Nevada
- New Hampshire
- New Mexico
- North Carolina
- Oregon

- Pennsylvania
- South Carolina
- South Dakota
- Tennessee
- Utah
- Vermont
- Virginia
- Washington
- Wisconsin
- Wyoming

EAST & MIDWEST

Alabama

Where to pan

Talladega National Forest – Shoal Creek & Talladega Ranger Districts

(Heflin / Talladega; Talladega Creek area)

USDA Forest Service

Hand panning permitted; GPAA and local sources say a free permit/letter from Shoal Creek Ranger Station (256-463-2272) is required and no sluice, highbanker or dredge

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r08/alabama/offices/shoal-creek-ranger-district>

Alabama Gold Camp

(Lineville, Clay Co.)

Private

Daily per-person fee for pan/sluice/detecting, extra for highbanker/dredge (≤ 5 in); RV and cabin camping; gear rental

<https://alabamagoldcamp.com/>

GPAA Alabama claims (Cornhouse Creek, Curvins Cow Pasture)

(Clay Co. area)

GPAA members only

Membership required

<https://www.goldprospectors.org/>

The rules in one paragraph

No state permit for hand panning on navigable public waters; mechanized gear may need state/federal permits. State parks (ADCNR) do not allow mineral extraction. Talladega NF: confirm permit requirement with the ranger district. Most gold ground (Hog Mountain, Arbacoochee) is private.

Check before you go:

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r08/alabama>

Alaska

Where to pan

Nome Creek Valley, White Mountains NRA

(Fairbanks, Steese Hwy MP 57)

BLM Eastern Interior FO (907-474-2200)

4-mile stretch between Nome Creek Bridge and Moose Creek; pans, rockers, hand sluices, picks/shovels; no suction dredges; season May 1 to Oct 14; road construction closures 2026

<https://www.blm.gov/visit/white-mountains>

Petersville Recreational Mining Area

(Trapper Creek, Petersville Rd)

Alaska DNR Div. of Mining, Land & Water

274-acre state area along Peters Creek closed to new claims; pan/pick/shovel free; dredges ≤18 hp need ADF&G + DEC permits, May 15 to Jul 15

<https://dnr.alaska.gov/mlw/cdn/pdf/factsheets/petersville-recreational-mining-area.pdf>

Caribou Creek Recreational Mining Area

(Glacier View, Glenn Hwy MP 104)

Alaska DNR

active floodplain of Caribou Creek; closed to mineral entry; general ADF&G permit with seasonal fish restrictions; steep foot trail, free

<https://dnr.alaska.gov/mlw/cdn/pdf/factsheets/caribou-creek-recreational-mining-area.pdf>

Hatcher Pass Public Use Area / Little Susitna River

(Palmer, 15 mi N)

Alaska DNR + State Parks

pan/pick/shovel anywhere except active claims; dredge ≤6 in/18 hp; Little Su is anadromous so ADF&G permit may be needed; Independence Mine SHP shovels-and-pans only

<https://dnr.alaska.gov/mlw/cdn/pdf/factsheets/hatcher-pass-public-use-area.pdf>

Resurrection Creek

(Hope, Kenai Peninsula)

Chugach NF, Seward RD

0.5-mile withdrawal upstream of Resurrection Pass Trail footbridge; pans and hand tools free; 4 in dredges May 15 to Jul 15 with ADF&G + ADEC permits; also Bertha, Sixmile and Crescent Creek panning areas

<https://www.detectorprospector.com/magazine/gold-prospecting/alaska-resurrection-creek-gold-panning-area/>

Nome East and West Public Beach Mining Areas

(Nome)

Alaska DNR

free state beach areas, open-water season roughly June to Sept; no winter under-ice dredging

<https://dnr.alaska.gov/mlw/factsheets/>

The rules in one paragraph

On BLM and state land hand tools, pans, rockers and hand sluices are permit-free; motorized equipment needs ADF&G fish-habitat and DEC permits and is season-limited on salmon streams. Private, Native-corporation and claimed ground is trespass without consent.

Check before you go:

<https://www.blm.gov/programs/recreation/recreation-activities/alaska>

Arizona

Where to pan

Lynx Creek Gold Pan Day Use Area

(Prescott, off Walker Rd)

Prescott NF, Bradshaw RD

withdrawn from mineral entry; pans and metal detectors; no sluices, dredges or drywashers; free; seasonal day-use hours, vault toilet, no water

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r03/prescott/recreation/lynx-creek-gold-pan-day-use-area>

Hassayampa River / Bradshaw Mountains BLM ground

(Wickenburg)

BLM Hassayampa FO

casual use (pans, hand drywashers <10 hp, detectors) on open parcels around heavily claimed blocks

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r03/prescott/recreation/rocks-minerals>

Gold Basin district

(Kingman, N)

BLM Kingman FO

popular nugget-detecting area; hand tools and drywashers on unclaimed BLM land

https://www.blm.gov/sites/default/files/documents/files/collecting_on_publiclands.pdf

The rules in one paragraph

Low-impact panning, hand collecting and metal detecting need no Notice of Intent on USFS; BLM casual use is permit-free. State Trust Land is closed to prospecting without a permit. Lynx Creek is the only free, designated USFS panning area in the state.

Check before you go:

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r03/prescott/recreation/rocks-minerals>

California

Where to pan

South Yuba Recreation Area

(Nevada City)

BLM Mother Lode FO + USFS + CA State Parks

Wild & Scenic South Yuba, hands-and-pans ONLY, no sluices or tools, free

<https://www.blm.gov/visit/south-yuba-recreation-area>

Keyesville (Keyesville) SRMA

(Lake Isabella, Kern River)

BLM Bakersfield FO

withdrawn area set aside for recreational mining; pans, non-motorized sluices and dry washers

(collection surface ≤ 6 sq ft); no highbanking, dredging or motors; free, 14-day dispersed camping

<https://www.blm.gov/visit/keyesville-special-recreation-management-area>

Forks of Butte Creek Recreation Area

(Magalia / Chico)

BLM Redding FO

mineral-withdrawn, numbered 100-yd sites; pans and hand sluices OK, no motors or highbanking;

historically a \$5/day site permit — confirm with Redding FO (530-224-2100)

<https://www.explorebuttecounty.com/activities/discover-the-forks-of-butte-creek-recreation-area>

Merced River Recreation Management Area

(Briceburg, Mariposa)

BLM Mother Lode FO

non-motorized panning along the Wild & Scenic Merced incl. Cable Rock day-use; some

grandfathered claims, check map at Briceburg Visitor Center; \$10/night campgrounds

<https://www.blm.gov/visit/merced-river>

Trinity River, Junction City reach

(Junction City / Weaverville)

BLM Redding FO

pans and small non-motorized gear at BLM access points along Hwy 299; respect active claims; no

suction dredging

<https://www.blm.gov/visit/junction-city-campground-0>

Marshall Gold Discovery SHP

(Coloma) and

Auburn SRA

(Auburn)

CA State Parks

hands-and-pans only (gold pan is the only tool allowed, 15 lb/day material limit, no metal detectors);

park day-use fee at Marshall

https://www.parks.ca.gov/?page_id=502

The rules in one paragraph

No permit for casual-use panning or non-motorized sluicing on BLM/USFS land open to mineral entry; suction dredging is banned statewide; State Parks are hands-and-pans only; National Parks closed. Wilderness and withdrawn areas have extra limits.

Check before you go:

<https://www.blm.gov/visit/south-yuba-recreation-area> (and the field office that manages your spot)

Colorado

Where to pan

Cache Creek Placer Area

(Granite, between Leadville and Buena Vista)

BLM Royal Gorge FO (719-269-8500)

not claimable; panning and non-motorized sluicing in a designated dig zone; motorized access

Memorial Day to Nov 30 (elk closure); BLM-approved fee \$5/day or \$25/yr — confirm enforcement

<https://www.blm.gov/royal-gorge-fo/public-room/map/blm-co-rgfo-cache-creek-placer-area-map>

Point Barr Placer Area

(Salida, 8 mi S on US 50)

BLM / CPW Arkansas Headwaters Rec Area

37-acre public placer; hand panning free (AHRA day fee); motorized gear needs a \$30/device/season permit from AHRA Visitor Center, Apr 1 to Sep 30, 4 in nozzle/8 hp limits; 4WD advised

<https://cpw.state.co.us/state-parks/arkansas-headwaters-recreation-area/arkansas-headwaters-recreation-area-salida-vallie>

Arapahoe Bar, Clear Creek

(Wheat Ridge, W of Youngfield St)

City of Wheat Ridge Parks (303-205-7550)

panning and sluicing in creek bed only between marked signs; battery gear in a box OK, no gas motors; free

<https://www.rootedinfun.com/facilities/facility/details/Clear-Creek-Trail-5>

Clear Creek Canyon Park

(Golden, US 6)

Jefferson County Open Space

~10 mi of creek; panning, sluicing, dredges ≤4 in; fill holes, no digging within 100 ft of structures; free

<https://www.jeffco.us/1196/Clear-Creek-Canyon-Park>

Fairplay Beach / Middle Fork South Platte

(Fairplay)

Town of Fairplay

pan/sluice downstream of the posted sign to the US 285 bridge; small permit booked through Town Hall

<https://www.uncovercolorado.com/activities/fairplay-beach/>

The rules in one paragraph

Casual-use panning on BLM/USFS is permit-free, but Colorado's best beginner spots are managed parcels with their own posted rules; motorized or pumped equipment on the Arkansas needs the BLM/CPW placer notification and reclamation bond and is closed Oct 1 to Mar 31 for trout spawning.

Check before you go:

<https://www.blm.gov/royal-gorge-fo/public-room/map/blm-co-rgfo-cache-creek-placer-area-map>

Georgia

Where to pan

Chattahoochee National Forest streams (Dahlonega, Chestatee, Etowah, Tesnatee drainages)

(Dahlonega / Helen)

USDA Forest Service, Chattahoochee-Oconee NF

Pan + small hand trowel only, in streambed only; no sluice, no dredge, no permit or fee; wilderness, scenic river corridors and some trout streams closed; confirm mineral ownership with district ranger

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r08/chattahoochee-oconee/about-area/faqs>

Consolidated Gold Mine

(Dahlonega)

Private

Underground tour + panning lesson, paid; open daily

<https://www.dahlonega.org/things-to-do/gold-mining/>

Crisson Gold Mine

(Dahlonega)

Private

Pay-to-pan by the pan or bucket; trommel use free with 6 buckets; open daily

<https://crissongoldmine.com/>

Dukes Creek Gold & Ruby Mines

(Sautee Nacoochee, near Helen)

Private

Gold panning buckets ~\$15; year-round

<https://exploregeorgia.org/sautee-nacoochee/outdoors-nature/gemgold-mining/dukes-creek-gold-and-ruby-mine>
s

The rules in one paragraph

No state permit for hand panning; EPD has a recreational mining exemption for non-mechanized panning (<https://epd.georgia.gov/recreational-mining-exemption>). National forest: pan and trowel only, streambed only, no sluices/dredges. State parks (incl. Smithgall Woods / Dukes Creek) prohibit panning. Private land needs permission.

Check before you go:

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r08/chattahoochee-oconee/about-area/faqs>

Idaho

Where to pan

South Fork Payette River, Sawtooth Wilderness boundary to Banks

(Lowman / Garden Valley / Banks)

Idaho Dept of Lands (riverbed)

state-designated public recreational mining section, closed to new claims; panning free, suction dredging needs the IDWR Letter Permit; steep canyon, expert water

<https://www.idl.idaho.gov/mining-minerals/dredge-placer-mining/dredge-and-placer-mining-frequently-asked-questions/>

Boise Basin — Idaho City area creeks (e.g., Bannock Creek)

(Idaho City)

Boise NF, Idaho City RD (208-392-3700)

casual-use panning on unclaimed NF ground; heavy claim coverage, verify first

<https://www.idl.idaho.gov/mining-minerals/dredge-placer-mining/recreational-mining/>

Salmon-Challis NF

(Salmon / Challis)

USFS

no designated panning area; casual panning allowed on open, unclaimed ground per forest guide

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/media/112818>

The rules in one paragraph

Pans and hand tools need no permit on open BLM/USFS/state riverbeds without claims. Anything that moves material with a sluice fed by a pump, or a suction dredge (≤ 5 in intake, ≤ 15 hp), needs the annual IDWR Small Scale Mining Letter Permit (\$10 resident / \$30 non-resident) with open-stream list and seasons; some waters (e.g., South Fork Boise below Anderson Ranch, North Fork/main Payette near Banks) are closed.

Check before you go:

<https://idwr.idaho.gov/form/stream/>

Indiana

Where to pan

Morgan-Monroe State Forest (Gose Creek, Deadman Hollow, Jordan Hollow)

(Martinsville, Morgan Co.)

Indiana DNR Division of Forestry

FREE gold panning permit from forest office (765-342-4026); pan only — no pick, shovel, sluice, or metal detector

<https://faqs.in.gov/hc/en-us/articles/115005242428-Is-gold-panning-allowed-on-Indiana-state-forests>

Yellowwood State Forest

(Nashville, Brown Co.)

Indiana DNR Division of Forestry

FREE permit from office (812-988-7945); pan only, same restrictions · same URL

Hoosier National Forest

(Bedford / Tell City)

USDA Forest Service

DNR says a free NF permit is required; hand tools, no motorized digging — call the forest office first

<https://www.in.gov/dnr/water/recreational-gold-prospecting>

The rules in one paragraph

DNR Division of Water "general license" (312 IAC 10-5-11, 312 IAC 6-5-10) covers panning, non-motorized sluice, pick/shovel, and suction nozzles ≤5 in, sunrise–sunset, no mercury/chemicals, written landowner permission; State Forests require an additional free permit and restrict to pans only. State parks and fish & wildlife areas: no prospecting.

Check before you go:

<https://www.in.gov/dnr/water/recreational-gold-prospecting>

Maine

Where to pan

Swift River at Coos Canyon

(Byron, Rte 17)

State rest area; riverbed private but panning customary

Hand pans, no bank disturbance; free; Coos Canyon Rock & Gift across road rents gear and gives free lessons May–mid-Oct (207-364-4900)

<https://www.maine.gov/dacf/mgs/explore/minerals/facts/goldfact.htm>

East Branch Swift River

(Byron)

Private timberland (historically Boise Cascade); panning with timber manager permission; work below water line only secondary (MGS lists stream; access status dated)

White Mountain National Forest – Maine side

(Bethel area)

USDA Forest Service

Free WMNF permit required; pan and hand trowel only

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r09/whitemountain/recreation/opportunities/other>

The rules in one paragraph

No state permit for hand panning if banks are not disturbed (38 M.R.S. §480-Q(5)); streambed is private — get permission. Motorized prospecting (≤ 7 hp) only Jun 15–Sep 15 and only in streams ≥ 4 ft wide, with some streams closed; Unorganized Territory follows LUPC Ch.10 §10.27,G.

Check before you go:

<https://www.maine.gov/dacf/mgs/explore/minerals/facts/goldfact.htm>

Maryland

Where to pan

Gold Mine Loop Trail (Maryland Mine ruins)

(Potomac, C&O Canal NHP)

National Park Service

Hiking/history only — NO panning

<https://www.nps.gov/choh/>

No verified free public site; no pay-to-pan options found in Maryland. The gold belt around Great Falls lies in C&O Canal NHP, where panning is prohibited; all state parks (Patapsco, Seneca Creek, etc.) are closed to collecting without Maryland Park Service authorization. Nearest beginner options: Monroe Park or Lake Anna in Virginia.

The rules in one paragraph

Panning only legal on private land with owner permission, hand tools; state lands closed without Forest & Park Service permission; federal park land needs superintendent approval (not granted recreationally).

Check before you go:

https://www.mgs.md.gov/geology/minerals_energy_resources/gold.html

Michigan

Where to pan

State forest / state game area streams where the State owns surface AND mineral rights
(e.g. Allegan State Game Area, Yankee Springs Rec Area, Green Creek – Muskegon Co.; reported by WOOD-TV, not DNR)

Michigan DNR

Hand panning year-round, no permit; ≤15.55 g (1/2 troy oz) gold per person per year; no digging banks; closed on designated trout streams, Natural Rivers, Great Lakes bottomlands, natural areas, mussel beds

<https://www.michigan.gov/dnr/managing-resources/minerals/recreational-gold-panning-and-sluicing-on-state-land>

Barkus Campground

(Pewamo, Ionia Co.)

Private

~\$10/pro prospector to pan Stony Creek (price from 2023 article; verify) · secondary source (Genesee County View)

No verified named DNR site; official policy is parcel-based — check DNR mineral ownership maps. Ropes Mine (Ishpeming) and most UP gold range ground is private/corporate.

The rules in one paragraph

Hand panning on qualifying state land: no permit, 1/2 oz/yr cap. Hand sluice requires EGLE Part 301 general permit (\$50), Jul 1–Aug 31 only, max 52x12x6.5 in, 300 sq ft area. No power sluices or dredges. State parks: no panning.

Check before you go:

<https://www.michigan.gov/dnr/managing-resources/minerals/recreational-gold-panning-and-sluicing-on-state-land>

Minnesota

Where to pan

Zumbro River near Oronoco / Zumbro Falls

(Olmsted–Wabasha Co.)

State-owned riverbed, public water accesses

Hand pan and hand shovel only; wading-level impact; no permit · secondary
(mindat/goldrushnuggets) — not an officially designated site

Vermilion River near Orr; Little Fork River near Cook

(St. Louis Co.)

State-owned beds, state forest frontage

Hand tools only; avoid designated trout streams without contacting Area Fisheries · secondary — not officially designated

No verified officially designated site; DNR publishes rules, not locations. No pay-to-pan gold sites found.

The rules in one paragraph

No permit for hand panning in state-owned beds of streams, rivers and lakes if impact is no greater than wading. Prohibited in state parks and SNAs (Minn. Rules 6100.0900). Officers can close sites during spawning or crowding. Sluices/dredges count as commercial — require permits and mineral lease.

Check before you go:

<https://www.dnr.state.mn.us/geologyrec/index.html>

Montana

Where to pan

Libby Creek Recreational Gold Panning Area

(Libby, 23 mi S)

Kootenai NF, Libby RD (406-293-7773)

withdrawn 30-acre area, pans/picks/shovels/buckets only — no sluices, rockers, motors, wheelbarrows or metal detectors; free, primitive camping, vault toilet

<https://visitmt.com/listing/libby-creek-gold-panning-area-6952>

Bannack State Park

(Dillon)

Montana State Parks

supervised weekend panning tubs in summer only (not free-range prospecting); park entry fee

<https://visitmt.com/things-to-do/gold-and-gem-mining>

Garnet Ghost Town

(Missoula, 1 hr E)

BLM Missoula FO

panning offered only during annual Garnet Day event; \$10 entry

<https://www.garnetghosttown.org/things-to-do.php>

Beaverhead-Deerlodge NF (Virginia City / Butte area creeks)

(Virginia City, Philipsburg)

USFS

casual panning on unclaimed ground; contact ranger district; county 310 permit may be required for in-stream disturbance

<https://fs.usda.gov/activity/bdnf/recreation/rocks-minerals>

The rules in one paragraph

USFS Northern Region and BLM Montana need no permit for gold panning or hand tools that cause negligible disturbance. Sluicing/dredging requires a 310 permit from the county conservation district, DEQ general permit for suction dredges (<4 in intake), and a Notice of Intent to the Forest. State trust land needs a Recreational Use License; state parks closed unless designated.

Check before you go:

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r01/natural-resources/geology/recreational-prospecting-montana>

Nevada

Where to pan

Rye Patch / Majuba placers

(Lovelock, ~22-45 mi N; west of Rye Patch Reservoir)

BLM Humboldt River FO (Winnemucca District)

famous chevron-nugget metal-detecting ground; hand tools, pans, detectors and drywashers on open BLM parcels; checkerboard with private railroad land and claims; no collecting inside Rye Patch SRA (state park)

<https://www.blm.gov/documents/nevada/public-room/brochure/collecting-public-lands>

Sawtooth Knob / Placerites / Rabbit Hole districts

(Lovelock / Winnemucca, Pershing-Humboldt counties)

BLM

shallow placers suited to drywasher and detector; verify claims in MLRS

https://pubs.nbmj.unr.edu/Recreational_gold_prospecting_p/gg12.htm

Unionville / Buena Vista Canyon

(Unionville, Pershing County)

BLM

historic placers, hand-tool casual use on unclaimed ground

<https://nbmj.unr.edu/GeneralGeology/Rocks&Minerals.html>

The rules in one paragraph

BLM Nevada "Collecting on Public Lands": gold and silver may be prospected with hand tools, pans and metal detectors without a permit on land open to prospecting; non-mechanical panning is even allowed in wilderness/WSAs if no surface disturbance. Sluicing, dredging or any mechanical equipment needs permits (contact NDOW for dredges; NDEP water permits). Nevada has 180,000+ active claims — claim checks are mandatory. No formally designated free panning parks.

Check before you go:

<https://www.blm.gov/documents/nevada/public-room/brochure/collecting-public-lands>

New Hampshire

Where to pan

Wild Ammonoosuc River & Tunnel Brook – White Mountain National Forest

(Woodstock / Easton, Pemigewasset RD)

USDA Forest Service

FREE annual permit from any WMNF district office required; gold pan and small hand trowel only; no shovels, sluices, rockers, or dredges

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r09/whitemountain/recreation/opportunities/other>

Wild Ammonoosuc River at Swiftwater Covered Bridge

(Bath, Rte 112)

Town-owned bridge access; adjacent riverbed private

Hand pans; landowner permission for riverbed; no shovel digging

<https://www.des.nh.gov/sites/g/files/ehbemt341/files/documents/2020-01/geo-1.pdf>

Twin River Campground

(Bath)

Private campground catering to panners

Pan on-site for guests · secondary source only (treasurenet) — verify

The rules in one paragraph

Riverbeds are privately owned by abutters — written permission needed outside the National Forest. Hand panning needs no state permit; no shovel digging in bed or banks. Sluice or suction dredge requires NHDES Wetlands Bureau permit (\$25 resident/\$50 non-resident, expires Dec 31). State parks: no collecting.

Check before you go:

<https://www.des.nh.gov/sites/g/files/ehbemt341/files/documents/2020-01/geo-1.pdf>

New Mexico

Where to pan

Hillsboro district placers (Animas Hills, Dutch Gulch, Rio Percha)

(Hillsboro, Sierra County)

BLM Las Cruces District + private

state's richest placer district; casual-use hand tools/drywashers on unclaimed BLM parcels; much of Percha Creek is private

<https://geoinfo.nmt.edu/resources/minerals/metalllic/gold/placer/home.html>

Pinos Altos / Bear Creek

(Pinos Altos, near Silver City)

Gila NF, Silver City RD

casual panning on open NF ground; heavily claimed, verify MLRS

<https://geoinfo.nmt.edu/resources/minerals/metalllic/gold/placer/home.html>

Jicarilla district

(Lincoln County, near White Oaks)

Lincoln NF, Smokey Bear RD

black-sand dry placers still worked recreationally; drywasher country

<https://geoinfo.nmt.edu/resources/minerals/metalllic/gold/placer/home.html>

Elizabethtown-Baldy / Moreno Valley

(Eagle Nest)

mostly private (Philmont etc.)

historic; limited public access, listed for context only

<https://geoinfo.nmt.edu/resources/minerals/metalllic/gold/placer/home.html>

The rules in one paragraph

No formally designated public panning parks. Hand panning, non-motorized sluicing, drywashing and detecting are casual use on BLM/USFS land open to mineral entry (no permit); state trust land needs State Land Office permission; tribal land is closed. Arid — expect drywashing. Check claims; many districts are blanketed.

Check before you go:

<https://geoinfo.nmt.edu/resources/minerals/metalllic/gold/placer/home.html>

North Carolina

Where to pan

Uwharrie National Forest – Uwharrie River & tributaries

(Troy / Eldorado, Montgomery Co.)

USDA Forest Service, Uwharrie Ranger District

Pan + shovel free, no permit; hand sluice/"shaker box" tolerated; no motorized gear, no digging banks, no wilderness or W&S river corridors; metal detecting not allowed

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r08/northcarolina/permits/recreational-mineral-collection> (county summary: <http://www.montgomerycountync.gov/visit/what-to-do/pan-for-gold-in-the-uwharries>)

Reed Gold Mine State Historic Site

(Midland, Cabarrus Co.)

NC Dept. of Natural & Cultural Resources

Pay-to-pan, about \$4/pan of real site ore, Apr 1–Oct 31, 9–4; site admission free

<https://events.dncr.nc.gov/reed-gold-mine>

Thermal City Gold Mine

(Union Mills, near Marion)

Private

~\$10/person/day pan or sluice native placer; trommel/highbanker rentals; camping; mid-Mar–Oct

<http://www.huntforgold.com/>

Lucky Strike Gold & Gem Mine

(Vein Mountain, Marion)

Private

River panning/own sluice for campers free, day panning small fee, sluice rental ~\$10; year-round

<http://luckystrikegoldandgem.com/>

The rules in one paragraph

No state permit for hand panning; rules depend on landowner. National forests allow pan/shovel without permit; no motorized or suction equipment without USFS authorization. State parks: no mineral removal at all. Most gold-belt land is private — get written permission.

Check before you go:

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r08/northcarolina/permits/recreational-mineral-collection>

Oregon

Where to pan

Little Applegate / Tunnel Ridge

(Ruch, near Medford)

BLM Medford District

withdrawn from mineral entry, pans and hand tools, free

<https://traveloregon.com/things-to-do/culture-history/historic-sites-oregon-trail/gold-panning-in-oregon/>

Gold Nugget Wayside

(Gold Hill, Rogue River)

BLM Medford District

small withdrawn waysides on Hwy 234, panning without claims, free

<https://traveloregon.com/things-to-do/culture-history/historic-sites-oregon-trail/gold-panning-in-oregon/>

Quartzville Recreation Corridor

(Sweet Home)

BLM Northwest Oregon District

recreational mining allowed on Quartzville Creek between Rocky Top Bridge and Galena Creek;

equipment rules vary year to year, Yellowbottom site itself excluded

<https://www.blm.gov/visit/quartzville-back-country-byway>

Cow Creek Back Country Byway (Island Creek area)

(Riddle / Roseburg)

BLM Roseburg District

~1,300 ft withdrawn segment, non-commercial panning and hand sluicing; no facilities, pack it out

<https://www.blm.gov/visit/cow-creek-back-country-byway>

Sixes River Campground

(Port Orford)

BLM Coos Bay District

designated panning area, non-motorized methods within the wetted perimeter only; open Memorial

Day weekend to Sept 30; campground fee

<https://www.blm.gov/visit/sixes-river-campground>

The rules in one paragraph

No federal permit for hand panning. State DSL removal-fill permit not needed for non-motorized work under 1 cu yd per site / 5 cu yd per stream per year in Essential Salmonid Habitat (50 cu yd elsewhere); stay in the wet channel, avoid fish eggs and spawning season. Motorized/suction dredging banned in ESH and needs DEQ 700-PM + DSL authorization elsewhere.

Check before you go:

<https://www.oregon.gov/dsl/WW/Pages/Mining.aspx>

Pennsylvania

Where to pan

State Forest streams (statewide, e.g. Clearfield Co. – Moose Creek / Little Clearfield Creek; McKean Co. – Potato Creek)

PA DCNR Bureau of Forestry

Recreational non-commercial hand panning permitted in State Forest rivers/streams except Wild & Natural Areas and EV/HQ waters; no bank/channel disturbance; no permit

<https://www.dcnr.pa.gov/StateForests>

York County streams (Bermudian, Conewago, Codorus, Muddy Creek tributaries) (Dillsburg / Castle Fin)

Mostly private

Hand pans with landowner permission · secondary source (raregoldnuggets.com) — not an official site

No verified named free public site; the DCNR authorization is forest-wide rather than site-specific. No pay-to-pan gold sites found in PA.

The rules in one paragraph

1961 State Forest Lands Prospecting Act allows casual prospecting on State Forest land; State Parks require written DCNR permission; State Game Lands — no removal. DEP: no permit for non-motorized pans/slucies; suction dredges/highbankers need a DEP permit. Avoid HQ/EV streams.

Check before you go:

<https://www.dcnr.pa.gov/StateForests>

South Carolina

Where to pan

Sumter National Forest – Long Cane & Andrew Pickens Ranger Districts

(Edgefield / Abbeville / Walhalla)

USDA Forest Service

Historically allowed with a FREE letter of authorization from the district office (pan + shovel only; no sluice or dredge; map of closed areas supplied). A 2026 forum report says Long Cane staff now say panning is not allowed — call to confirm (Long Cane RD 803-637-5396)

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r08/francismarionsumter>

No verified free public site currently confirmed open; no pay-to-pan sites found in SC. Nearest beginner pay-to-pan options are in NC (Reed, Thermal City) or GA (Dahlonega).

The rules in one paragraph

SCDHEC does not regulate recreational panning or small dredges; mining permit needed only for bank disturbance/excavation. State parks and WMAs prohibit collecting. Sumter NF requires written authorization; mechanized gear not allowed. Most gold ground is private — get written permission.

Check before you go:

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r08/francismarionsumter>

South Dakota

Where to pan

French Creek, Custer State Park

(Custer)

SD Game, Fish & Parks

hand panning in designated areas along the 1874 discovery creek; no sluices, digging banks or motors; park entrance fee

<https://gfp.sd.gov/parks/detail/custer-state-park/>

Rapid Creek / Castle Creek near Rochford

(Rochford / Hill City)

Black Hills NF, Mystic RD

casual panning and hand sluicing on unclaimed NF ground; many claims incl. GPAA club claims

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r02/blackhills/recreation/gold-panning-rockhounding-metal-detecting>

Spring Creek / Battle Creek drainages

(Hill City / Keystone)

Black Hills NF

same casual-use rules; fine flour gold

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r02/blackhills/recreation/gold-panning-rockhounding-metal-detecting>

The rules in one paragraph

Black Hills NF allows panning and sluicing with hand tools without authorization but has no designated panning sites; closed in wilderness, acquired-mineral lands and withdrawals. South Dakota exempts hand-tool recreational mining (pans, sluices, detectors) from state permits; a DANR mine permit is required for any dredge or mechanized gear. Private inholdings and claims are common — use the forest map.

Check before you go:

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r02/blackhills/recreation/gold-panning-rockhounding-metal-detecting>

Tennessee

Where to pan

Lyons Creek & Wildcat Creek – Cherokee National Forest, Tellico RD

(Tellico Plains / Coker Creek)

USDA Forest Service

Only designated Class 1 hand-panning streams; pan and hand tools, no mechanized gear; no permit fee; stream maps from Tellico RD (423-253-8400)

https://www.fs.usda.gov/sites/nfs/files/r08/cherokee/publication/2025%20JH%20DRAFT_Gold%20Collecting-Fact%20Sheet.pdf

Coker Creek Gold Camp

(Coker Creek, Hwy 68)

Private

Pay-to-pan on private frontage of Coker Creek; call (850) 354-2279 for hours

<https://www.visitmonroetn.com/gold-panning>

Coker Creek Welcome Center

(Coker Creek)

Monroe County tourism

Info, maps, and (reported) permit registration for NF panning

<https://www.visitmonroetn.com/gold-panning>

The rules in one paragraph

No state permit for hand panning. Cherokee NF allows hand panning only in designated streams; Coker Creek itself is closed on NF land (sediment-impaired, mercury in sediments) — private property only. Class 2 (mechanized) prospecting is not permitted anywhere in the forest.

Check before you go:

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r08/cherokee/recreation/coker-creek>

Utah

Where to pan

American Fork Canyon (above and below Tibble Fork Reservoir)

(American Fork / Pleasant Grove)

Uinta-Wasatch-Cache NF, Pleasant Grove RD

most consistent recreational panning in the state; pans and non-mechanized gear on unclaimed ground; canyon recreation fee (\$10/3 days)

<https://geology.utah.gov/popular/general-geology/rocks-and-minerals/utah-gold/recreational-gold-panning-and-dredging-regulations/>

Crescent Creek, Henry Mountains

(Hanksville, 25 mi S)

BLM

fine placer gold; casual use hand tools; verify claims

<https://geology.utah.gov/popular/general-geology/rocks-and-minerals/utah-gold/recreational-gold-panning-and-dredging-regulations/>

Johnson and Recapture Creeks, Abajo Mountains

(Monticello / Blanding)

Manti-La Sal NF / BLM

fine placer, hand panning

<https://geology.utah.gov/popular/general-geology/rocks-and-minerals/utah-gold/recreational-gold-panning-and-dredging-regulations/>

The rules in one paragraph

Non-mechanized panning needs no state permit on BLM/USFS land without claims. Any suction dredge (≤ 4 in, ≤ 12 hp) or hand sluice work in a stream channel needs the free annual Recreational Dredging permit from the Division of Water Rights (reissued each April, 45 days/yr, open-stream list) plus prior notice to the land agency; Green, Colorado and San Juan rivers are closed. SITLA trust lands need a lease.

Check before you go:

<https://www.waterrights.utah.gov/strmalt/default.asp>

Vermont

Where to pan

Camp Plymouth State Park – Buffalo Brook

(Plymouth / Ludlow)

Vermont Forests, Parks & Recreation

Hand panning only, east of park entrance; no sluice, rocker, or motorized gear; day-use fee

<https://vtstateparks.com/plymouth.html>

Rock River

(Newfane / South Newfane / Dover)

Mixed private and town land; listed by Vermont Geological Survey

Hand pans; landowner permission needed off public ground

<https://dec.vermont.gov/sites/dec/files/geo/StatewidePubs/rockhound3.pdf>

Williams River

(Ludlow / Chester, along VT-103)

Mixed private; VGS-listed

Hand pans; landowner permission · same VGS PDF

Mad River

(Warren / Waitsfield / Moretown)

Mixed private; VGS-listed

Hand pans; landowner permission · same VGS PDF

The rules in one paragraph

No state permit for hand panning with minimal disturbance. FP&R lands: traditional hand panning only. Sluice boxes allowed only on private land with landowner permission AND a DEC Rivers Program mineral prospecting permit (802-828-1115). Green Mountain NF: hand tools as casual use; check Manchester/Rochester RD.

Check before you go:

<https://dec.vermont.gov/sites/dec/files/geo/StatewidePubs/rockhound3.pdf>

Virginia

Where to pan

Lake Anna State Park – Goodwin Gold Mine tour & Gold Panning on the Beach

(Spotsylvania)

Virginia State Parks (DCR)

Ranger-led programs, Memorial Day–Labor Day Wed–Sun plus some weekends; beach panning free, mine tour/pan \$3 pre-registered; park parking fee applies; no self-guided panning

<https://www.dcr.virginia.gov/state-parks/lake-anna>

Gold Mining Camp Museum at Monroe Park

(Goldvein, Fauquier Co.)

Fauquier County Parks & Rec

Free daily panning demos Mar–Nov 2 pm; paid sluice with purchased gem/gold bag (cash only); Wed–Sun

<https://www.fauquiercounty.gov/government/departments-h-z/parks-and-recreation/facilities/parks/monroe-park>

George Washington & Jefferson National Forests

(Roanoke / Harrisonburg; little placer gold)

USDA Forest Service

Hobby panning allowed without permit for personal use; no mechanized gear; metal detecting restricted

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r08/gwj/forest-products/recreation-mineral-collecting>

The rules in one paragraph

No state permit for hand panning; regulated by Virginia Energy and DEQ general environmental law. The Piedmont gold-pyrite belt is mostly private — written permission required. Contrary Creek (Louisa Co.) is often cited but access is from road right-of-way only; not an official site.

Check before you go:

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r08/gwj/forest-products/recreation-mineral-collecting>

Washington

Where to pan

Liberty / Swauk Creek

(Liberty, near Cle Elum)

Okanogan-Wenatchee NF, Cle Elum RD

state's most popular panning area; casual use on unclaimed NF ground (many active claims — check MLRS); Gold and Fish pamphlet rules and work windows apply

<https://wdfw.wa.gov/sites/default/files/publications/02150/wdfw02150.pdf>

Sultan River / Skykomish River

(Sultan, Gold Bar)

mixed USFS/DNR/private; Snohomish County

hand pan and small sluice under pamphlet; Spada Lake watershed above Culmback Dam closed

<https://wdfw.medium.com/panning-for-gold-in-washington-waters-rules-hot-spots-and-tips-628ded956b7a>

Snoqualmie River / Tolt River

(North Bend, Carnation)

mixed public access

pamphlet rules; fine gold in gravel bars

<https://wdfw.medium.com/panning-for-gold-in-washington-waters-rules-hot-spots-and-tips-628ded956b7a>

Wenatchee River / Peshastin Creek (Blewett district)

(Leavenworth)

Okanogan-Wenatchee NF

casual use, check claims; pamphlet work windows

<https://wdfw.medium.com/panning-for-gold-in-washington-waters-rules-hot-spots-and-tips-628ded956b7a>

The rules in one paragraph

Carry the current WDFW "Gold and Fish" pamphlet — it is your free Hydraulic Project Approval for pans, mini-rocker boxes and small non-motorized sluices, with river-by-river in-water work windows to protect fish. Any motorized method (dredge, highbanker) needs a written HPA plus an Ecology NPDES permit. State Parks are closed to panning; DNR aquatic lands may need authorization.

Check before you go:

<https://wdfw.wa.gov/sites/default/files/publications/02150/wdfw02150.pdf>

Wisconsin

Where to pan

Nugget Lake County Park – Plum Creek

(Plum City, Pierce Co.)

Pierce County Parks

Panning openly welcomed in creek bed only, no bank digging; pans loanable at office; park entry

~\$5/day (715-639-5611)

<https://www.mindat.org/loc-25689.html> (site history; confirm fees with park)

Chequamegon-Nicolet National Forest streams

(Medford / Taylor Co., Black River headwaters)

USDA Forest Service

No permit; pan, small shovel, hand pick only; disturbance <1 sq ft spots, <40 sq ft per 500 ft of stream, <5 days/yr; no sluice, dredge, chemicals; trout waters closed before Apr 15 and after Sep 15; no wilderness/RNA

<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r09/chequamegon-nicolet/recreation/opportunities/other>

The rules in one paragraph

DNR requires no mining or water permit for non-mechanized panning removing ≤ 2 cu yd per waterway per year; DNR-owned property may need a collector's permit from the property manager; state parks closed. Public-trust navigable waters can be waded, but minerals belong to the riparian owner — get permission.

Check before you go:

<https://dnr.wisconsin.gov/topic/Mines/GoldPanning.html>

Wyoming

Where to pan

South Pass City State Historic Site

(Lander / Atlantic City, Hwy 28)

Wyoming State Parks

teaching panning with staff and \$5 guaranteed-flake bags; no collecting inside site boundary

<https://windriver.org/experience/gold-panning-ghost-towns/>

Rock Creek / Atlantic City area BLM

(Atlantic City)

BLM Lander FO

panning for personal use allowed outside active claims (many claims — check MLRS); hand tools only

<https://experience.arcgis.com/experience/cbaa2b72d3c64982bcd08136939194ba>

Douglas Creek district

(Fox Park / Laramie)

Medicine Bow-Routt NF, Laramie RD

popular amateur placer area; in-stream work season reported as Jul 1 to Sep 10 for trout — confirm with district

<https://main.wsgs.wyo.gov/mineral-resources/metals/mining-districts/medicine-bow-mountains>

The rules in one paragraph

BLM Wyoming: personal-use panning is allowed on BLM land outside existing claims with no permit or charge. State DEQ/LQD does not regulate recreational panning with hand tools; dredges >3 in intake or >10 hp, or motorized trenching, need LQD permits. Checkerboard ownership — verify land status.

Check before you go:

[https://www.blm.gov/sites/blm.gov/files/documents/files/WYNF-0004_rockhounding%20\(051418\).pdf](https://www.blm.gov/sites/blm.gov/files/documents/files/WYNF-0004_rockhounding%20(051418).pdf)

Your state isn't listed?

- Call the nearest **BLM field office** or **Forest Service ranger district** and ask: "Are there any areas open to recreational gold panning near me?"
- Search your state's **geological survey** or **department of natural resources** site for "gold panning".
- Join a local **GPAA chapter** or prospecting club. Many own claims their members can pan.
- No gold nearby? Use Bonus 4 and practice at home with paydirt.

Ezra says: "Every creek I ever loved, I found by asking somebody who'd been there first."

First Flake: Josie's 7-Trip Field Workbook · Bonus 1. General information, not legal advice. Always confirm current rules with the managing agency.